

OnePlus Nord Buds 3r

Affordable TWS that don't compromise quality

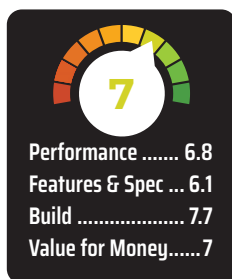
OnePlus Nord Buds 3r launched in India as the brand's new entry-level true wireless earphones (TWS), priced at Rs 1,799. The main attention areas are long battery and bass sound. The earphone also features a 12.4mm dual driver setup, pre-tuned EQ presets, OnePlus 3D Audio compatibility with select OnePlus smartphones, 47ms low latency (in Game Mode), touch controls, and AI call noise cancellation. Therefore, it is designed for users who want a feature-packed earphone without straining their budget. But, should you consider it? Are there any corners cut, and most importantly, how good do the OnePlus earphone sounds for the asking price? Let's find out. I have been listening to it for some time now, and below is a closer look at how it performs in design, features, audio quality, and overall usability after extended testing.

VERDICT

The OnePlus Nord Buds 3r delivers energetic sound and solid comfort for the price. Its V-shaped tuning works well for bass-heavy genres like EDM and pop, though it trades some detail and openness for impact. While the soundstage feels a bit closed, the overall energy makes up for it. Battery life and connection stability are strong, and while it lacks active noise cancellation (ANC), passive isolation remains decent due to the snug fit. Overall, it's a reliable, fun-sounding budget TWS that favours punch over precision, and that is okay.

UNBOXING AND DESIGN

The Nord Buds 3r box includes the



earbuds, the charging case, a set of eartips (small, large, medium pre-installed), paperwork and a sticker. Our review unit has the Aura Blue colour, while you can also pick the earbuds in Ash Black colour.

The case looks chic in blue, sporting an angular design and a matte finish. The OnePlus logo is centred on the front, and a small LED indicator sits below it to show the charging and pairing status. There is a USB-C port at the bottom. And that's it, there is nothing else on the surface. Very neat, indeed!

The case is compact and comfortable to hold, and easy to slip into a pocket. The lid can be opened with a single hand by pushing a little with the thumb. Let's come to the buds now.

The Buds 3r has a stem-style design. The stem isn't too long and sits snugly in the ear. The in-ear seal is also tight, which provides passive isolation even without ANC. You can comfortably wear them for extended sessions, and the lightweight design helps prevent fatigue. Build quality is also fine for the price. The plastic

body doesn't feel cheap, since it is finished well.

I also appreciate OnePlus for offering IP55 dust and water resistance on their entry-level buds.

PAIRING AND SOFTWARE

The pairing process was simple thanks to Google Fast Pair. Open the case, with the earbuds still nested in, and once the LED indicator on the case turns white on its own, you'll see Fast Pair notification on your phone. Press connect and that's it. I connected it to a OnePlus 13. Despite its budget positioning, the Buds 3r doesn't feel stripped down due to this and its dual-device connection. By the way, there is gatekeeping too, as certain features like OnePlus 3D Audio and AI Translate will work when paired with supported OnePlus phones. But these aren't deal-breaker features. So, it is fine.

If you use a compatible OnePlus phone, you can access these settings within the phone's Bluetooth settings page. In case of other brand phones, all of these settings will be available to tweak in the HeyMelody app (downloadable via the Google Play Store and the Apple App Store).

Either way, the OnePlus buds offer the following settings and features that you can tweak:

- Firmware updates.
- Earbud controls. You can assign single/double/triple tap(s) or a long touch and hold for various functions. The Triple Tap function lets you access the voice assistant, Game Mode, and AI Translate option.
- Sound Master EQ includes three preset equaliser profiles: Balanced, Serenade, and Bass, and an option to create a custom EQ curve. We conducted all sound tests in the Balanced mode, which is the default profile. More on the sound in the later section.
- Other features include Find My earbuds ring, the option to enable Dual connection, and Game Mode that drops latency to 47 ms.